

EPISODE 21 (SESSION 1)

# With All Your Soul & “Very”

PRIMARY TEXT: EXODUS 17

SECONDARY TEXTS: Psalm 78, Numbers 10, Judges 6–7

*Hear, O Israel! The LORD is our God, the LORD alone. Love the LORD your God with all your heart, with all your soul, and with all your might, and love your neighbor as yourself.*

The Jesus Shema.

In the Gospels, Jesus declares this as the greatest commandment, and in the story of Exodus, the Israelites are tested in the ways that challenge them to *listen* and *obey* this command. Through these tests in the wilderness, the people are brought closer to God and God to them.

**...the people are brought closer to God and God to them.**

Their hearts are tested.  
Their souls are tested.  
Their strength is tested.

We see God’s frustration and Moses’s fear with the grumbling and demands of the Israelites. Miracle after miracle has been done, yet when the so-called mountaintop moments come to an end, they, and we today, settle into doubt.

*Why me? Why now?  
This is not what I had planned.  
Maybe this was the wrong plan all along.  
Things were so much better! I’d be better off on my own!*

**God meets Israel where they are at again...**

So God sets Himself before His people—again and again—just as He did before the mountain in Exodus. He responds with more grace and more love, more grace and more love. God meets Israel where they are—again—in their confusion and anxieties, to restore and strengthen their souls so we all can see what it looks like to love the Lord our God with all of our *nephesh*.

In the face of fear and frustration with the people God has called him to lead, Moses continues to speak on their behalf. To stand with them before God, and he is one who is called to use *all* of his strength for others—including those who continue to speak against him (and God). Yet, we also see Moses’s strength alone wasn’t enough; others came alongside him when even he was weary.

So often we've seen characters such as Moses or Joseph or Jacob or Isaac as these standalone figures whom God called, but as we're learning, there is so much more going on in their context—in their stories. There's a communal aspect, the radical hospitality of their forefathers, that sticks with them and that their larger community is invited into.

The call to use *all* your strength to protect those who are in the most need—who have the least power, who are hungry or weak or weary of growing faint—is not because they deserve it, not because they've done the work, not because they will owe you in return, but because all your strength isn't just meant to be the one person giving their all until there is nothing left to give. Our strength is greater as a collective whole. A community that loves God and loves others, so that the weak and weary will never be, or feel, alone.

We continue to see how this God is different. His Kingdom seems backwards or upside down in comparison to our modern empires that are stuck asking God to prove Himself and increase our might, rather than giving up ourselves not just for Him, but for others. It can be exhausting and painful and dirty work.

But when we see ourselves not as our own lonely islands vying for survival, but partners in a larger community coming together to heal the broken state of our world, the work becomes beautiful and life-giving and oh-so-very good.

It becomes more like the garden, as things were meant to be.

**...giving up  
ourselves  
not just for  
Him, but for  
others.**

## PRAYER

*God,  
In spite of Your wonders and miracles  
there are days where we don't believe.  
Yet, You remain  
the rock and the banner before us.  
Help us to always remember  
that our strength and might comes from You.  
Continue to remind us, and show us.*

*May we love You with all our heart,  
with all our soul, and with all our might,  
and love our neighbors as ourselves.*

*Amen*

# THE FOUR PILLARS

## EPISODE 21

BEMA Discipleship is built on four pillars; a **Four-Pillared Perspective** to help us remember **to elevate the words of God** (not ours) and help us identify the principles that we see recurring in the Story of God's people.

Here are some applications for this episode echoing the ideas of the four pillars:



### TEXT

*What might be important to meditate over from Exodus 17? What Text could you meditate on, memorize, or dig deeper into? What resonates with you or challenges you to read more?*



### COMMUNITY

*How does your community follow God with all your soul and "very"/strength? Who does, or could, you surround and protect, heal, or care for?*



### DISCIPLESHIP

*Who in your life would benefit from a mentor-like relationship that modeled loving the Lord your God with all your heart, soul, and might? Who needs to see in real time what it looks like to hear Jesus's words and partner with Him in fulfilling the greatest commandment?*



### WRESTLING

*What are you wrestling with? What is unsettling or confusing? About God's "testing" or Israel's grumbling? The journey to Horeb or the banner raised in the wilderness? What could you study more deeply? Remember—wrestling is good! (Especially in community.)*



### Are you a music listener?

Listen along to our BEMA Music Playlists on Spotify.

Song suggestions? Send them to [bemabesorah@gmail.com](mailto:bemabesorah@gmail.com).



BEMA SESSION 1



MEDITATION & PRAYER

# REFLECTION, APPLICATION & IMPACT

There are three emphases we are always thinking about in terms of application at BEMA. These may be stated explicitly at times, but often we will want you to do the work of finding ways to connect the dots to the things we are learning. Much of this is what makes the work of BEMA distinct as a ministry of Impact Campus Ministries.

## CREATING A SPACE *SPIRITUAL FORMATION*

*What spiritual practices or disciplines might you need to connect with God? We believe that **if we do our part in creating space for God, He will fill it.** How might the smallest practice make you readily available to God—to give Him all your heart, soul, and strength? How have you created space to hear God speak? What ways for Him to really know you, and you likewise to know God, could you practice? Could it begin with memorizing and reciting His Shema?*

## CONSIDERING CAMPUS *YOUNG PEOPLE FOCUS*

***We believe young adults are shaping the future,** and they need to be shown by people just like you how to hear and obey Jesus's greatest commandment. To gather around the poor, weak, oppressed, and marginalized to protect and love them with all of their strength. A love and desire so much like Jesus's that it becomes contagious and life-giving to find strength in God's people as a community. Young adults are open to this Jesus—they just need people to show them. What young adults might you invite into this journey?*

## SACRED STATION *THEOLOGY OF WORK*

*Living out the Jesus Shema isn't just for Sunday mornings or Bible study; it's about living and breathing Him in our everyday lives. How might you put this call of God on display in how you pursue and experience your 9–5? Does our physical work put the marginalized—the alien, orphan, and widow—in the center of our communities to come alongside and protect? The way we manage our employees, interact with customers or coworkers, care for our children, or create products should bless others and show God's love. **You are doing a sacred work—no matter where you are. Do it with all your heart, soul, and mind.***